

Kalie Jia
Ms. Tatar & Ms. Pespisa
D Block Yellow
Oct 24, 2023

"I did it!"

My eyes hurt. My lips cried out for water. I kept my head down on the ground, staring blankly at the white cement sidewalk. The bits and grains of sand and dust shone like a million little mirrors back at me. I could almost see myself, exhausted and glum. The heat was making me want to take a nap— "woah," My sister let out.

I finally looked up from my shoes, curious to see where we were. I winced as the sun's rays pierced my eyelids, and then—woah, I thought.

A huge pendulum ride swung up, then scooped back down like a sledgehammer. From the bottom, you had to shield your eyes to get a glimpse of its silhouette against the white sun. I winced with every swing. It was almost teasing, going up until it was parallel to the sky and then hammering back down toward the ground but never actually hitting it. Music blasted, thundering my ears.

I gulped water nonstop as if it would make my fright go away. I was zoned out for what seemed like a trillion years!

No way am I doing that, My mind flew back to the time in second grade when I went on a pendulum ride called the *Freak Out!* and I almost fell off the seat because: (1) My body was too small, and (2) I wasn't properly secured in with the latch. *Amusement park rides... amusement park rides are just not for me.*

As I shifted my gaze away, the roller coaster was just starting. It started climbing, slowly at first, up, up, up. All that cracking noise that it let out was even more alarming. The people on the seats were still, clinging on for their lives. Disturbed, I sunk my eyes back down toward the

ground. *As long as I stay on the ground, everything will be fine. The concrete is so nice and sturdy, ready to catch you any moment.*

“Do you want to try the rides?” My uncle asked my siblings and I.

No.

Without waiting for an answer, though, he marched over to the ticket counter and came back with three all-ride tickets.

No, no, no!

I crossed my arms and rolled my eyes, appearing uninterested. *Sane humans would know not to take a walk outside at noon when it's 95 degrees out!*

I looked at my parents, frustrated. Usually my dad would be on my side, saying that amusement park rides were not good for you. Instead —probably because we were with our uncle— he skillfully avoided my eye contact. *I'll have a little chat with you after, dad. You betrayed me!*

“Which one do you want to do first?” My uncle waved the tickets in the air.

“Let's start with the swings!” My sister replied.

“Yup. Sure.” My brother studied his ticket.

“C'mon, Kalie!”

Before I knew it, I was trailing behind my siblings as they bounced after my uncle to the first ride: the swings.

I mean, of course I'm not scared or anything. I'm just not in the mood, that's all.

“What's wrong, Kalie?” My uncle came up to me. “How come you're not going?”

“I just don't want to!” I snapped.

“Fine,” My uncle handed me my ticket. “We have plenty of time for you to decide.”

While my brother and sister were doing the swings, my parents and uncle hurried over to take pictures and wave hysterically.

I slumped down under a conveniently located tree, and watched my brother and sister get secured into the seats.

What am I going to do? I panicked silently. I waited as the swing started slowly, making a *whirring* sound.

What if my family blames me for being so negative? Now the ride was gradually speeding up while inching its way to the very tip top.

What will uncle think of me? I haven't seen him for so long. I don't want to spoil the reunion. The swings were like a carousel in the air. My siblings flew in circles round and round, dangling loosely like marionettes ready to fall off every moment.

My sister waved to me every time. My brother was expressionless. A tiny lump of regret rolled around in my stomach. I didn't want to refuse because my uncle already bought the tickets. But on the other hand, I wasn't scared— that's an understatement— but *petrified* of the rides.

My brother and sister eventually came back to the ground, safe and sound.

"It was amazing!" My sister exclaimed. She was grinning from ear to ear.

After that, they decided to take a break and go on the dino ride, the kind where you spin in circles and can control whether you go up or down. My sister pulled me into the same dinosaur car. My brother followed us as we went up, and down, up, and down. I felt like a little kid again, and the joy and excitement of the amusement park came flooding back.

The next ride was a wet one.

If you've ever been on the Boston Tea Party ride in Canobie Lake Park, you would understand. This ride's cars only held two people, though, and the structure was lower. You'd be wrong if you think the ride is over after the first dip, because that's only a warmup for the second one.

My brother and sister went first. I watched behind the railings, chewing on the tip of the plastic water bottle.

My dad pushed me forwards. "Come on, you go, too."

I swallowed. *Listen to yourself, Kalie. What are you getting yourself into?* Silently, I stepped in, and the supervisor helped me into my own raft.

Before I knew what was happening, my raft was already starting to climb up, up, up. Up the conveyor belt. I sank down in my seat, regretting all the decisions I just made.

This couldn't be happening.

I glanced over at my family.

"You got this!" My sister was doing all thumbs up at me.

C'mon, Kalie. This is supposed to be fun. Try to enjoy this. I took a deep breath, and closed my eyes when starting to make the turn.

Now.

Anytime now.

Nope. Not yet.

I peeked open my eyes, and immediately wished I hadn't. I plunged down, and a shock of exhilaration penetrated me. The second drop was taller, and an entire wave swallowed me. I found myself laughing, as if I forgot all about my nerves. The thrill was amazing!

I was dripping from head to toe when the ride was over.

“That wasn’t bad, was it?” My uncle exclaimed. “Let’s take a break and go on a walk for now.”

“Will we go back to do the roller coaster and the other rides next?” My brother hurried to catch up with us.

“Yeah, definitely.”

I helped myself to the ice cream stand and closed my eyes as I let the ice pop’s refreshing mung bean flavor wash over my tongue. The river’s surface shimmered like a dragon’s scales. The willow trees bowed on either side of it, as if paying their respect. Everything was just too peaceful to match my worrying.

Everything’s going to be fine, I can almost hear the trees whispering.

I thought about how proud I would be of myself if I went on the pendulum ride and the roller coaster. I thought about me, on my deathbed, never been on one of those rides ever in my life.

I also imagined myself saying, “*I did it!*”

* * *

20 minutes later I found myself getting latched into the seat, kicking off my crocs. I couldn’t believe it. Around me, thick metal bars as wide as a railroad rose up and met together on the very top. I looked across my shoulder, at my brother and sister. They were probably feeling the same as I was.

If other people can do it, so can I, I took a deep breath.

Soon my body was paralyzed by the roaring of the music and the blast of air that hit my face as I was sent into turbulence. I had no idea what my limbs were doing at that point.

Scream! I remembered what my sister told me to do before going on. *It's going to make you feel better.*

When I was about to open my mouth, I realized that I had already been doing it on autopilot. After a while, my body became used to it. I wasn't as tense as before anymore. Each swing became a rhythmic beat, just like on a metronome, except this one was magnified 1000 times. Just as I felt I was brave enough to open my eyes, the ride started slowing down and eventually it was over. I hopped off, dazed but surprised. Thoughts like '*I can't believe it!*' and '*That was so fun!*' raced through my mind.

The rest of the afternoon went by with soda, laughter, and embarrassing videos.

"Look! That's you!" My uncle zoomed in on his phone's screen. I pushed his screen away, cracking up. Nevertheless, I could hear the one single scream going on nonstop.

Yup. That's me.

The golden sun spilled its warmth all across my body. I took a long, cool sip of water. Even the water tasted sweet. I felt my feet planted, once again, on the unmoving earth below me.

Now I felt that all my worries had done nothing to stop me from trying a new, but scary thing.

I did it.

Just a while earlier, I would not have thought the same. It was surprising how a mere 15 minutes would change an entire piece of you.

I turned to look up at the roller coaster, swiveling and looping and diving. "Let's ride the roller coaster next!"